719. Such marks were a mathematical impossibility due to the "+4, -1" scoring system: four marks for a correct answer, one negative mark for a wrong one. Says Dr Sanjeev Singh, medical director, Amrita Hospital, Faridabad, "It could be either 720 or, if one question attempted was incorrect, you'd get 715. Or, one no-answer could give you 716. A score of 718 or 719 is not possible."

It didn't take long for NEET to renew its old history of legal trouble. On June 11, responding to petitions that sought the cancellation of the exam, the Supreme Court issued notice to the Centre and the NTA and said the "sanctity of the exam had been affected...so we need answers". The counselling process for admissions is to continue for the moment, the next hearing is on July 8.

Controversy dogged NEET 2024 from the start. Soon after the May 5 exam, police busted an illegal operation in Patna that involved everything from a question paper leak to impersonators appearing for actual candidates. A day prior, an organised 'paper leak gang' allegedly hawked the question paper to anyone willing to pay Rs 30-50 lakh, and put them up in two hostels where they could mug up the answers. An examinee, among the 13 arrested, confessed they were given the same question paper that the actual exam had. Sixteen impersonators—including senior students and even a lecturer—were arrested in a parallel crackdown.

Adding to the mess: the "arbitrary" award of grace marks to 1,563 students in centres (including in Jhajjar) where confusion reigned over two sets of question papers. One paper was replaced after about 40 minutes and students had complained to the NTA. A student from Jhajjar, expecting 670 marks, was initially foxed after getting 720—till it transpired that a bunch of students had been granted grace marks to compensate for lost time, which also led to odd scores like 719. On June 13, a four-member panel formed by the NTA told the court the 1,563 students could retake the test on June 23, or accept their original scores—minus the grace marks. Some 44 perfect scores are now ascribed to a revised "answer key".

Conceived in 2010 as a way to create a level playing field—at a time when a boom in private institutions with high capitation fees had created an unhealthy skew—NEET became in many ways a case of hasty reform gone wrong. Rolled out in 2013, it sought to integrate under a single exam a sprawling medley of admission procedures and venues that forced exam-bound aspirants to "criss-cross India". Many institutions then followed the All India Pre-Medical Test, some prestigious ones (both public and private) held their own exams, several state-level medical colleges used school-leaving marks as a basis for admission. Language was another source of terror for aspirants, with only English and Hindi allowed in the initial years (eight other languages have been introduced since 2017). Add to this the differences between state syllabi and those followed by the two main national boards, the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) and the Indian School Certificate Examinations (ICSE). The plethora of challenges from several states—and private colleges that feared loss of control over admissions—brought NEET under the judicial lens almost immediately after birth. In August 2013, ruling on 115 petitions, the SC declared NEET to be "unconstitutional". The exam was cancelled for 2014 and 2015.

Its legal restoration in 2016, after review petitions by the Centre, ran headlong into tragedy with the 2017 suicide of 17-year-old S. Anitha, the daughter of a Dalit daily-wager from Ariyalur, Tamil Nadu. Anitha had scored 1,176 out of 1,200 in her state Class 12 exams, including 100 per cent in Physics and Maths. A year ago, she'd have been in a medical college on that basis. But after the Madras High Court disallowed exemption to TN, Anitha impleaded herself in the review plea. The SC held the same line. Lawyer Nalini Chidambaram, appearing for pro-NEET students, said "any further appeal can only be to God". Nine days later, Anitha did precisely that: hanged herself in her village home. It made her an emblem for the dissenters, who say a unified test favours a mechanised standard that can be produced by coaching factories, inevitably favouring existing social elite. In NEET 2023, a study found 74 per cent from the Top 50 were from city schools—most had coaching.

NEET 2024 holds the key to 188,398 seats. The NTA, an autonomous body set up in 2017, started conducting the exam in 2019. Its invigilation is clearly not quite at a perfect 720 yet. ■

TESTING ISSUE

- **NEET is a single door to medical colleges and allied pursuits–AYUSH, dentistry et al–at the undergrad level. Across India, 188,398 seats are at stake in 2024**
- **Some 2.4 million aspirants took the test, conducted by the National Testing Agency on May 5**
- **Controversy erupted when 67 students score 720 out of 720, and a few others, 718, 719**

MANY ARGUE THAT A UNIFIED TEST LIKE NEET FAVOURS A MECHANISED STANDARD THAT COACHING FACTORIES CAN PRODUCE